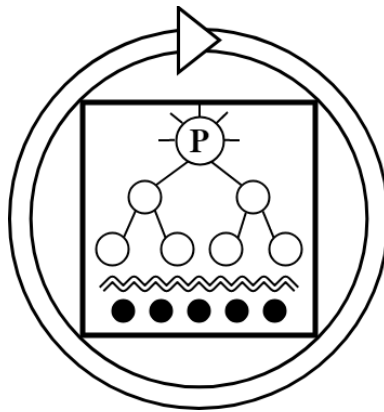


Reconstructing the Narrative

A Literary Antidote to the **Meaning** Crisis



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This is where people thank others for what they have done themselves.

Themselves or, rather, who they call "I", which, ultimately, is nothing but the creation of those who cared; of those who once upon a **time**, maybe forever, **loved** – without question.

God, **agape**, 神性: for many names only one; eternal, universal, yet so close, so deep.

To **you**: thank you.

ABSTRACT

The **Meaning** Crisis is the state we are currently living in, a **time** of great disagreement, confusion, and suffering, where the mechanisms we used to employ in **order** to properly extract **meaning** and progress towards **wisdom** are failing us.

This project aims to be a literary response (and, hopefully, antidote) to the **Meaning** Crisis.

In **order** to do so, I explore how the **Meaning** Crisis expresses itself in the stories we read through a historical analysis of the development of narratological models.

Firstly, I delve into the **teleological** narrative and how it was **transformed** by the **Enlightenment**.

Secondly, I analyze how the **cyclical** narrative of Modernism and **Postmodernism** was a critical response to the pitfalls of the **teleological** narrative.

Finally, taking into account the strong and weak points of both the **teleological** and the **cyclical** narrative, I propose my own narratological model, called the narrative of traditional cosmology, which aims to be a bridge between the two, combining them together into a single model of production, analysis and consumption of literature.

To conclude, I suggest that a model like the narrative of traditional cosmology could be a potentially successful antidote to the **Meaning** Crisis in the realm of literature, while also stressing the importance of practice and communion with the art of the word.

Keywords: **Meaning** Crisis, Re-embedding, Narratology, **Meaning**, **Wisdom**

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1. INTRODUCTION

1.1. *Motivations Behind this Study*

"And thou shalt remember all the way which the Lord thy **God** led thee these forty years in the wilderness, to humble thee, and to prove thee, to know what was in thine heart, whether thou wouldest keep his commandments, or no." (Deuteronomy 8:2, KJV)

I started attending university in 2015. At the **time**, I had no great expectations, I was just hoping to live some new experiences, meet new people and learn some things along the way. However, the last four years I have been set on an adventure that has far surpassed my wildest dreams, although not precisely because of university itself, but rather due to my exposure to a greater phenomenon around it that has shaken my view of the world. In 2016, after the infamous Donald Trump got elected as president of the United States, I had the opportunity to witness a rather bizarre and yet fascinating event: I was in class, the day after the election. We were discussing the topic with our professor at the **time**, and the atmosphere of the classroom was not precisely joyful. Among the student's facial expressions there was confusion, dis**belief** and even anger. Suddenly, the door opened; an unknown student poked his head in from the door and shouted: "Trump 2016, deal with it!" and ran away. In among the puzzlement of some and the laughter of others, a small group of female students ran towards the door to persecute the anonymous student; they were not happy at all. They felt personally attacked and responded furiously to the whole incident. This completely surreal situation seemed to me quite funny at first, but upon further examination, it made me feel worried and occasionally depressed. What was going on exactly? Why was there a feeling of tension and hostility all around the world? As this issue became more salient to me, I began to notice even more weird phenomena and behavior all around me: a significant number of parents started to doubt the effectiveness or even necessity of vaccines; more and more people, especially young men, suddenly became obsessed with Buddhism and Mindfulness; sexual promiscuity became the default sexual conduct among women close to me, my male friends periodically asked me for advice because they felt insecure as men, and many other phenomena. Meanwhile, in the social network I personally frequent, people were "comically" implying that they wished to die, while simultaneously in the UK the first cause of death among men between 20 and 40 is suicide (Office for National Statistics, 2015). In general, people complained about feeling isolated, disconnected from the world around them, while messaging from the slim yet thick screen of their smartphones. Even I would find myself entangled in a mixture of all of the previous, which paradoxically concluded in my rediscovery of my Christian faith. Something strange was going on, and I desperately needed answers. Consequently, a bit over a year ago, I began a quest to nail down and understand the roots and implications of these complex social and cultural phenomena that are persistently affecting the Western world in an un**predictable** and dramatic manner. My Treball de Fi de Grau is all about my findings regarding this issue, what I will be referring to as the **Meaning** Crisis, a term suggested by John Vervaeke and his colleagues (Vervaeke, Mastropietro, Miscevic, 2017).

Nevertheless, I am not a sociologist, nor a psychologist or a cognitive scientist; I have been trained in the arts of the word, I am indeed a philologist. Therefore, my point of view is always going to be from the word up; from the story to the individual and beyond. As a result, in my TFG I am going to craft an argument for the existence of the **Meaning** Crisis from the perspective of narratology, followed by a suggested literary antidote to said crisis: a pragmatic solution in the form of a narratological model of literary practice and analysis. My premise is the following: lives are stories, and therefore lives are informed by stories. If we could **change** the way in which we approach stories, in theory and practice, that could greatly help us **change** the way in which we approach life itself. This whole project is an attempt to shake and revive the mythological "grammar" (Nietzsche, 1982/1889) coded in our thought, to hopefully reactivate it and enhance it, so it can serve as a stepping stone in **order** to escape from the **Meaning** Crisis that is tearing apart the Western world as we know it.

1.2. *Introduction to The Meaning Crisis*

The **Meaning** Crisis is an extremely complicated phenomenon to point to and define. There are compelling **reasons** as to why it remains a relatively obscure issue.

First and foremost, it is a very recent phenomenon, it is in fact taking place right now, nowadays, everywhere.

Second of all, there is very few academic / **scientific** research on the topic, although it is slowly becoming a priority, especially in the Cognitive **Science** departments around the world (for instance, Ferrari, Weststrate, 2013). This is partially due to its novelty, but also because some researchers either do not understand the importance of it, or are not aware of the concept. This note is not precisely a criticism towards the academic world, it is simply meant to show how entangled we are in this jumble of dis**belief**, skepticism and confirmation-bias.

The **Meaning** Crisis is best identified in its consequences, in its effect on the real world. People are completely aware that there is something wrong with the way things are going, but find themselves so immersed in the whole mess that end up unable to actually act against it; the current is too strong for some to swim against it.

Regardless, for the purpose of this study I do have to define what exactly the **Meaning** Crisis is. The main challenge is that the **Meaning** Crisis is an incredibly extensive and dense topic, it ranges in all sorts of branches: from philosophy to psychology, from psychology to sociology, etc. However, in **order** to put the issue into words and synthesize it as much as possible, I do need to take a particular approach: the literary point of view. I am going to focus on how the **Meaning** Crisis lays itself out in the literary sphere, in the narratives, in the stories that inform us.

1.2.1. What do we Mean by *Meaning*?

To start with, it is important to address the words that form the concept itself. In the modern world, we are perfectly aware of what a *crisis* is, we feel it, we are conscious of being in a state crisis as if it was an instinct. A *crisis* is a "time of great disagreement, confusion, or suffering" ("crisis", 2019), where the mechanisms to act against suffering either fail us or have been lost. To us, *crisis* is not a troublesome term at all, we breath it continually.

However, what does *meaning* mean exactly? When someone says: "my life has no *meaning*", or "this experience was extremely *meaningful* to me", what is that *meaning*? To put it simply, we could think of *meaning* as "what we extract out of *wisdom*". But then again, we hit another wall. What is *wisdom*? In our currently hyper-connected world, if we seek information, we look things up on the internet; if we seek knowledge, we go to university; but where do we go when we seek *wisdom*? We have lost our connection with this ancient term, to the point where not only defining it is a complex task, obtaining it is a true ordeal. The Cambridge Dictionary defines *wisdom* as: "the ability to use your knowledge and experience to make good decisions and judgments" ("*wisdom*", 2019). Therefore, it is related to action (*to make* good decisions and judgments), to knowledge, and to the *good*.

In this instance, "good" is referring to *meaning*; "what is good to us in a profound way" is precisely what we mean by *meaning*.

However, we first need to determine what is *good*, and distinguish it from what is not; we are after that distinction. Therefore, the process of realizing what is *good* to us in a profound manner [i.e. *meaning*] using our knowledge is *wisdom*.

In the words of John Vervaeke, professor at the University of Toronto in the departments of psychology, cognitive *science* and Buddhist psychology, "*wisdom* is about realizing, in both senses of the word, ('becoming aware' and 'making real'), *meaning* in life [i.e. "what is *good* to us"] in a profound way" (Vervaeke, 2019a).

Importantly, the realization of that "good" is not a trivial intellectual or spiritual reward, but rather the very essence of what makes life rewarding; it is the fruit of properly aimed purpose.

1.2.2. Definition & Project Thesis

If we bring together what we have explored so far, we can assert that the **Meaning** Crisis is the state we are currently living in, a **time** of great disagreement, confusion, and suffering, where the mechanisms we used to utilize in **order** to properly extract **meaning** (the engines of **wisdom**) are failing us. This definition constitutes a theoretical base for all academic disciplines to research on the **Meaning** Crisis. Nevertheless, for the purposes of this study, we need to explore how this affects literature. How is the **Meaning** Crisis represented in the way in which we read, write and analyze stories? This is one of the main questions I am going to be addressing throughout the paper; we are going to come back to this issue repeatedly, but to start with, the thesis of this project is going to be the following:

Postmodernism has been "*re-embedding*" literature (Taylor, 2012) into the **cyclical** narratological model, the literary model of the **continuous** cosmos [terminology developed and explained in section 3], and that has created a gap between the stories we read and the cognitive grammar we actually utilize to extract **meaning**, which is not **cyclical** in nature. As a consequence, the stories we largely consume nowadays do not match our grammatical structure responsible for the extraction of **meaning**, which corresponds to the model of traditional cosmology: a two-world mythological cosmos [terminology developed and explained in section 2.2]. This has created a situation where we cannot make communion with texts at a profound level, they do not inform the **meaning** in our lives, nor do they train our **wisdom**. We are stuck in a superficial state of shallow **meaning** and shattering distrust. On the one hand, recently produced contemporary texts do not satisfy our necessity for **meaning** due to the nature of the **cyclical** narratological model they largely follow. On the other hand, the way in which we approach and read classic texts is incomplete, confirmation-biased, and fundamentally fragmented at the mythological level. Consequently, because lives are stories, and therefore, lives are informed by stories, the way in which we act and think has become confused, fragmented, biased, and ultimately devoid of **meaning**; a perfect environment for "*bullshit*" (Frankfurt, 2005). My argument is that there is no distinction between the way in which we treat our stories, and the way in which we treat our lives. A possible solution to this situation could be a re-conceptualization of the narrative, which I am going to propose in this project; a novel narratological model I called "the narrative of traditional cosmology". Primarily, it attempts to revive the forgotten **meaning**-extracting mechanisms of **wisdom**, while simultaneously remaining conscious of the world we currently live in, as well as the literary theories that form our contemporaneous perspective. Its main emphasis are purpose, communion and practice in the narrative realm.

1.3. Procedure

The **Meaning** Crisis is present in the way in which we write and read stories, they both feed upon each other.

To better understand the current situation and find **reasonable** solutions, I will analyze the structure of the following narratological models, in **order** to gain a greater historical perspective:

- The **teleological** narrative; which although it is **sometimes** labeled as the "traditional narratological model", I will mainly relate to the **Enlightenment**. The main goal of this analysis will be to understand how this model came to be, and what its strong points and weaknesses are. The question that needs a crucial answer is: why was this model rejected by **(Post)modernism**?
- The **cyclical** narrative; which is mainly attributed to **(Post)modernism**. It stands as a critical response to the linear nature of the **teleological** narrative. The main themes of this analysis will be: What important problems is this model addressing? Why is it so relevant and intellectually seducing for the current academic world? Which are its major pitfalls? How does this model relate to the **Meaning** Crisis?

Finally, I will argue in favor of a 'new' narratological model, which is in essence a re-conceptualization of the narrative as understood in traditional Biblical cosmology. This model is meant to be a response to the **Meaning** Crisis, an antidote to its catastrophic symptoms from the realm of literature. I will define its complete and complex structure, aimed at addressing all major flaws presented in the previously mentioned models, as well as enhancing the strong points of both.

Lastly, I will illustrate how each narratological model lays itself out in texts by providing prototypical examples of each. Moreover, I will be continually providing schematic diagrams throughout the project, depicting each and every structure, as to furnish my **reasoning** with clear visual representations that will hopefully ease comprehension.

2. THE TELEOLOGICAL NARRATIVE

2.1. Definition

The word "**teleological**" derives from the Greek *telos* (end, goal, purpose) and *logos* (**reason**, explanation).

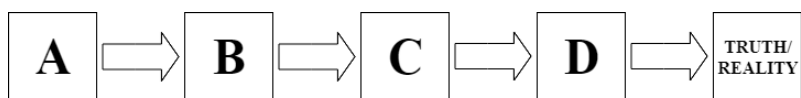
From the **teleological** point of view, things are defined and explained in function of its end and purpose.

Consequently, we could define the **teleological** narrative as:

- a story
- where every step points to a final destination or goal;
- where the narrative course is always directed by a natural and intrinsic purpose.

It also relies heavily on cause and effect, as each narrative step causes the effect of the following step, gradually driving the story towards an inevitable **truth**.

It is therefore often associated with **reason**, realism, and the **Enlightenment**.



□ —> Fixed space; predictable causality.

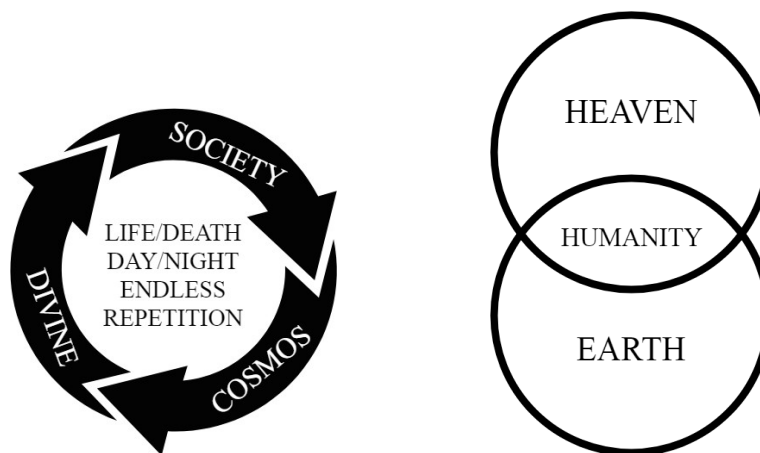
*The fundamental structure of the **teleological** narrative.*

2.2. Two-World Mythology

The origin of what we now understand as **teleology** is to be found in ancient Greek mythology, more specifically in the writings of Plato and Aristotle. Both philosophers are key for Western civilization, especially Plato, as, together with Jesus Christ, they are the most influential figures in history, responsible for the cognitive grammar structures we utilize in **order** to think and create **meaning**. The main difference between the Greek philosophers and Jesus of Nazareth is that, while the greatest minds of the Greek ancient world usually depicted their **reasoning** by means of matter (for instance, Aristotle explaining **teleology** in terms of an acorn having the purpose to become an oak tree) (Aristotle, 1981, 1050a9–17)¹ or brief myths, the Christian tradition dramatizes the notion of purpose and progress in the form of a historical fiction. In both instances, however, there is a great insistence on purpose, goals and progression. Why do these crucial historical figures insist so much on these concepts? More importantly, where do these ideas come from?

- 1 Ancient Greek philosophers provided **material** explanations which are to be read as both physical examples and analogies. The concept of purpose also applied to non-**material** realities, such as politics, philosophy and life itself.

The root of the notions of purpose and progress is the Axial Revolution. Before the Axial Age (8th-3rd century BCE), religious narratives embedded people together in a **continuous** cosmos, an inescapable natural **cycle**. In the words of Charles Taylor, in the **continuous** cosmos "human agents [were] embedded in society, society in the cosmos, and the cosmos incorporated the divine" (Taylor, 2012, p. 34). It was a conceptualization of the world where everything was interconnected in a single reality, where the natural laws constituted the world: day and night, life and death, continually repeating themselves endlessly. We are going to come back to this idea of the **continuous** cosmos later; for now, I just want to make the following point: The Axial Revolution **disembedded** us from the **continuous** cosmos and brought forth an incredibly novel way of understanding the world: a two-world mythology (Taylor, 2012. Vervaeke, 2019b).



*The fundamental structures of
the **continuous** cosmos (left) and the two-world mythology (right).*

The two-world mythology emerged from the Axial Age as a response to the Bronze Age collapse, a dark period of history where an innumerable amount of cities and civilizations go out of existence.

In **order** to survive and overcome this crisis, human beings had to create new and powerful psycho-technologies, which resulted in the genesis of the religions we now embody (Christianity, Buddhism, etc.), as well as philosophy, as Karl Jaspers and Michael Bullock argue in *Origin and Goal of History* (1953).

The two-world mythology is essentially the bases of all these psycho-technologies, and is responsible for the cognitive grammar we now utilize to generate **meaning**.

Its crucial innovation is that it is based on the idea that there are two worlds, as opposed to one.

Due to the huge **influence** of the **scientific** world view in our modern understanding, these concept may be misunderstood as a claim only about **material** reality, or simply as a metaphor, but for ancient people it was a transcendental **truth**.

This new narrative symbolically dramatized a conceptualization of reality that would bring forth civilization as we now know it.

If we were to distill the two-world mythology and explain it plainly, it would read:

Human beings are living in the **material** world,
in "the everyday world;
the world of the untrained mind" (Vervaeke, 2019b),
a realm of suffering and self-deception, or sin if you will.

However, by means of training their **wisdom**, their mind and body, human beings can overcome, or *transcend* this world and come into contact with the world of the **gods**, a world of **truth**, where everything becomes clear and real.

Notice this crucially important distinction:

While

in the world of the **continuous** cosmos the aim of **wisdom** is to control the world you embody, the reality you already possess, and make it great and prosper,

in the two-world mythology the goal is to transcend the current state and move into a higher and more real actuality.

In other words,
the two-world mythology incorporates progress as the main mechanism of **wisdom**.

Meaning is no longer a connectedness to the everyday world, but "a special kind of connectedness" to the real world, the transcendent world. (Vervaeke, 2019b)

This is the origin of the **teleological** narrative:
from one superficial state, into a higher reality; from the everyday world, into the real world; moving forth towards a final destination or goal. It is the beginning of the narrative of *telos*.

2.3. The **Enlightenment**: from **Belief** to **Reason** – from **Participation** to **Authority**

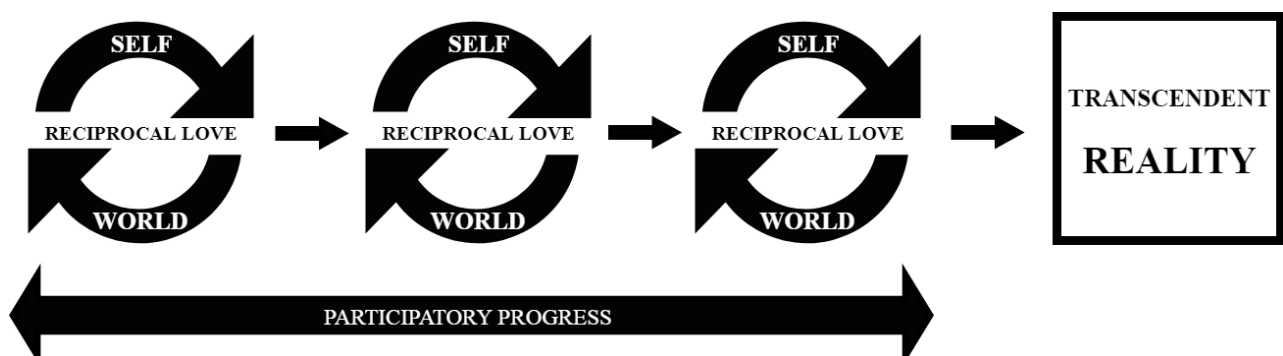
The **teleological** narrative has been commonly attributed to either 'traditional literature' or the **Enlightenment**, although I have already argued for its ancient genesis. However, there are good **reasons** as to why I exclusively associate the concept "**teleological**" to the **Enlightenment**. The difference-maker is the way in which the **Enlightenment transformed** the two-world mythological worldview, mutating it and simplifying it due to the **influence** of the **scientific** worldview, which was powerfully emerging during the period. What the **Enlightenment** did was substitute **belief** for **reason** as the main pathway towards the real world. **Belief** slowly became a sort of synonym for "superstitious false knowledge", and was dismissed as a proper mechanism to acquire **wisdom** and therefore transcend the everyday world.

Originally, the way in which human beings were called to transcend the everyday world and advance towards the "**Promise Land**" of the trained mind was **belief**. Unfortunately, this word has become absurdly useless in our modern conception, as it now does not hold any of the **meaning** that it previously had. What is **belief**? According to the Christian tradition, **belief** is nothing other than **love**. However, that is again another word which no longer holds any real **meaning** for us nowadays. John Vervaeke and his colleagues have been arguing for a re-conceptualization of terms such as **meaning** and **belief** from a cognitive perspective (Vervaeke, Mastropietro, Miscevic, 2017), in an attempt to make sense of them as they truly reveal themselves to us.

To phrase it simply, **belief** and **love** are forms of **participatory** knowledge:

you **change** who you **love**,
and they **change** you,
and when you **change**,
it **transforms** the way in which you **love**,
and as you continue to **love**,
you **transform** more who or what you **love**,
and that again makes you develop further.

There is **solid scientific** literature supporting this argument: numerous studies on the flow state show this exact same process and reliably relate it to **love** and **belief** towards a specific task (Csikszentmihalyi, 1990). There is also substantial religious evidence to support that this is precisely how ancient people thought of these terms. In the gospel of John it is written: "**God** is **love**, and whoever abides in **love** abides in **God**, and **God** abides in him" (John 4:16b, KJV). Furthermore, the Bible also links together notions such as **love** and **wisdom** through **participatory** knowledge: "And Adam **knew** Eve his wife" (Genesis 4:1, KJV).



*The **teleological** narrative before the **Enlightenment**.*

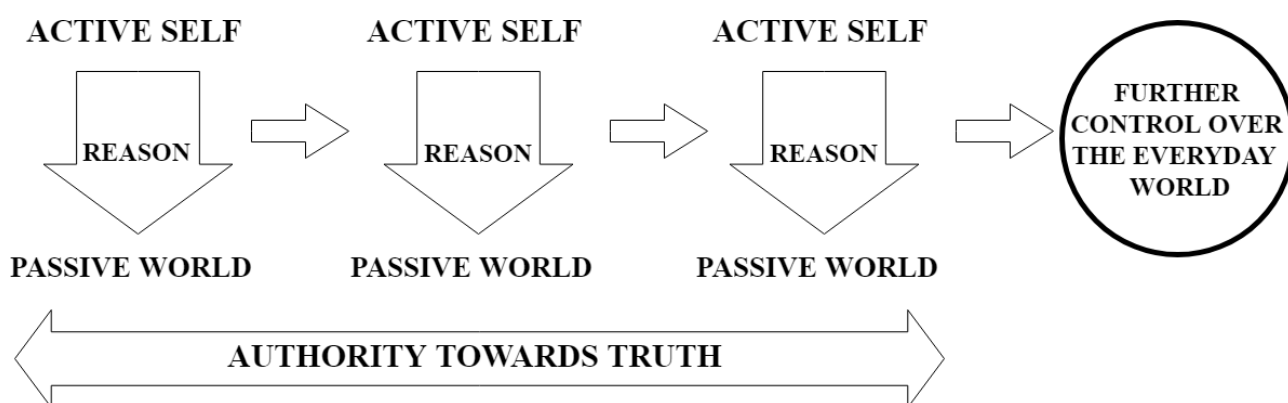
Nevertheless, during the **Enlightenment** the **scientific** worldview that was predominantly emerging **transformed** this conceptualization of the world. The **materialist** view of the world that is paired together with the **scientific** method made **believe** and **love** no longer reliable sources for **wisdom**. The symbolic language of the religious narratives was interpreted purely **rationally** through **material causality**, and much of the **meaning** that previously disembedded us from the everyday world was lost. As a substitute, **reason** emerged as the default vehicle towards the real world. Nevertheless, the cognitive grammar utilized in **science** is still that of the two-world mythology: scientist want to **progress** from the everyday world towards a more real world, where they are more in touch with reality and **truth**; they aim to decrease self-deception. However, even though we still use it, that language does not match our current **materialistic** conceptualization of the world. Consequently, as people disassociated themselves from the true **meaning** of the language of the two-world mythological narratives, the world we aspired to reach through progress slowly became more akin to the one we already inhabit.

More importantly, another crucial shift in conceptualization began to develop. As the ideas of **love** or **believe** were dismissed, we slowly lost the sense of **participatory** knowledge (which is precisely why nowadays we find verses such as "And Adam **knew** Eve his wife" kind of amusing, we cannot connect with them).

The worldview that took over our model of reality is not only driven by **reason**, but also by another notion embedded within **rationality**: **authority**. There is an enormous difference between **participating** in the act of knowing something (**believe** / **love**) and conquering or forcefully revealing the **truth** (**reason**). The former implies a dance of thought, an engagement with the world; you are not just looking and discovering, you are in a flow of revelation where, as you uncover more **truth**, you also reveal your true self to the world; it is **participation**. The later, however, implies a certain distance: we do not talk about "**scientific** relationships with the **truth**", but rather about "**scientific observation** of the **truth**". As a consequence, we create a subject/agent distinction; it is the emergence of the passive and the active entities of knowledge, where the role of the active agent is to impose its **authority** over the passive subject through **reason**.

This development leads directly to Nietzsche's **Will to Power**, not only for the **rational scientific** person, but also for the artist. Beauty is no longer conceived as a harmonious **participation** with everything, but rather as a form of powerful **authority** towards the chaotic nature of the world:

"Beauty is for the artist something outside all **orders** of rank, because in beauty opposites are tamed; the highest sign of power, namely power over opposites; moreover, without tension: – that violence is no longer needed: that everything follows, obeys, so easily and so pleasantly – that is what delights the artist's WILL TO POWER" (Nietzsche, 1968).



The teleological narrative after the Enlightenment.

3. THE CYCLICAL NARRATIVE

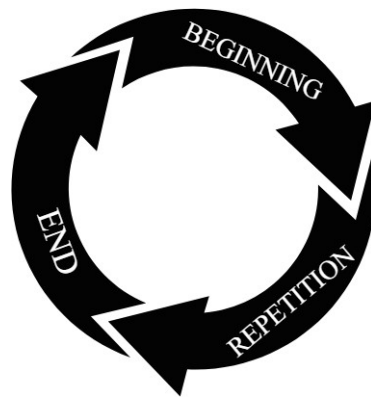
3.1. Definition

In a **cyclical** narrative, the beginning of the story is the end, or the end is the beginning; the start and the end of the narrative meet.

Crucially, there is typically a conscious sense of **repetition** during the narrative itself, both for readers and characters, which most commonly serves a function in and of itself and provides narratological tools that linear narratives cannot offer to the same degree.

Paradoxically, it is precisely in the **repetitions** where the narrative develops, and every loop brings forth new elements which **transform** the **meaning** of the text.

Although some classic stories and even myths utilize a kind of "**cyclical** narrative" (*Alice in Wonderland*, by Carroll, 1865/2000, for instance), it is currently most well-known as a narrative style developed by Modernism and **Postmodernism**, and I am going to be referring to the **cyclical** narratives of this period specifically (late 19th century until today).



*The fundamental structure of the **cyclical** narrative.*

3.2. *Emergence and Development – Modernism and Postmodernism*

We should understand the emergence of the **cyclical** narrative as a critical response to the **teleological** model of the **Enlightenment**.

As **reason**, **causality** and **authority** over **truth** became more prominent in literature, a set of writers became aware of many of its pitfalls (which I will describe in this section).

Among those writers, we should list names such as James Joyce, Virginia Woolf, Fyodor Dostoyevsky, Walt Whitman, and others.

All of them were heavily **influenced** by Nietzschean-like ideas (or those of similar thinkers or **authors**), not in the emphasis of power, but rather in one of the most crucial concepts of Modernism:

the idea that psychological drives were somehow more important than facts (**reason** / **truth**).

Indeed, something that characterizes the pioneers of the modern **cyclical** narrative is a heavy emphasis on the psychology of characters and the multiplicity of the mind.

This collection of writers aimed to reject the modern understanding of human experience as a mere cause and effect chain that could be predicted by **reason**.

Hence, the Modernist period was characterized by heavy literary experimentation, often utilizing the stream of consciousness methodology.

The **cyclical** narrative was revived as a result of this experimentation.

Most likely, it developed from the psychology characters, to the narrator, into the narrative form itself.

A perfect Modernist example of a **cyclical** narrative would be James Joyce's *Finnegans Wake* (1939/2012), where the last sentence of the book is linked together with the first line in an endless **cycle**.

Later on, **Postmodernism** fully embraced the **cyclical** narrative in some of the most iconic works of the movement, such as Samuel Beckett's *Waiting for Godot* (2011), or other popular works of contemporary literature such as Stephen King's *The Dark Tower* (1998-2004) series. Crucially, **Postmodernism** more clearly and neatly defined the critique towards the **teleological** narrative of the **Enlightenment**, which, for the sake of simplicity I am going to nail down to some points:

- The **Enlightenment** rejected the metaphysical transcendence of the two-world mythological narratives, reducing the notion of progress to **material** progress in the everyday world through **reason**. **Postmodernists** reject their **teleology** because they consider **reason** and the human mind to be too unreliable, as well as multiplicitous, simultaneous and complex for us to control or understand. This is what I call "the **Postmodern** distrust".
- Before the **Enlightenment**, the two-world mythology called forth humanity to transcend the everyday world by acting upon it, training **wisdom**, and joining it with the world of the **gods**. However, as a result of the **scientific** worldview, our understanding was reduced back to a one-world view where **authority** over **truth** through **reason** was paramount. The **Postmodernists** critique this: if there is only one world and we are supposed to control it with **reason**, we have failed the task.² Therefore, if we are incapable of ruling the world with our unreliable tools, *it is the world who rules us* (e.g. *The Crying of Lot 49*, by Thomas Pynchon, 1966).
 - 2 In other words, "the **Postmodern** distrust" leads them to **believe** that control over the everyday world is futile/impossible. Arguably, this doubt sees its origins in some decades of skeptic thought throughout the Modernist period and the psychological aftershock of WWII.
- **Postmodernists** reject the idea that our minds can rule the world, therefore, knowledge of it is not possible (Hall, 2001), as a consequence, many **Postmodern authors** play with the idea that **wisdom** and progress are an illusion.
 - 3 Hence Zygmunt Bauman's term "liquid modernity", as opposed to "**Postmodernity**" (2000).
- **Postmodernists** claim through their literature and theory that the world rules us in a **cyclical** manner; that certain patterns repeat endlessly throughout history and that we are condemned to play along (similarly to Marx's and Engels' *The Communist Manifesto*, 1967). In other words, it is the narrative who rules over us, not us who rule over the narrative. As a consequence, one of the most key **Postmodern** concerns will be to identify what that narrative is, which they typically recognize as power over the economy, the "oppressed", minority groups, different identities, morality standards, voices, etc.

Another crucial innovation of **Postmodern** literary theory is to claim that we find **change** (as opposed to progress) in the **repetitions** of the **cyclical** narrative.

This relates to **Postmodern** ideas of paranoia (Bersani, 1989), where the **repetitions** cause a **transformation** in the consciousness of characters and readers alike, who struggle towards a **truth** that ultimately does not exist.

For **Postmodernists**, the goal of **repetitions** is essentially a **transformation** of identity and a redistribution of power.

As the **repetitions** go on, paranoid tendencies augment and therefore maintain "the polarity of self and non self" (Bersani, 1989), defining the identity of all conscious entities, both inside and outside of the text.

The notion of power, however, has less to do with **Postmodern** theory and more to do with the nature of **cyclical** narratives themselves.

I argue that the **Postmodern** emphasis on power and their usage of **cyclical** narrative forms is no accident, but actually a natural link.

As John Vervaeke argues (Vervaeke, 2019b), the **meaning** and **wisdom** mechanisms of **cyclical** or one-world mythological narratives is power oriented.

The goal is not to transcend, but rather "to live prosperous and long lives", which has nothing to do with virtue, but rather with power.

We can see this clearly in the ancient Greek myths, where the **gods** are no different from humans or animals:

they fall for their desires, seek ultimate power, lie, self-deceive themselves, kill out of rage instead of justice, etc.

The Greek **gods** have nothing to do with the Axial **God** of the Israelites, they are like day and night, because in one-world mythology, deities, humans and other sub-consciousnesses all coexist in the same world.

Therefore, what is the ultimate difference between humans and **gods**?

Power.

The **gods** are more powerful than us.

In **cyclical** narratives:

- the world is viewed as a huge **cycle** where power is being delivered and distributed;
- where the final goal is to identify where the power lies and take control of it,
- maybe even "redistribute it in an egalitarian fashion".

In other words, the **Postmodern** agenda.

3.3. The Re-Embedding

The *re-embedding*, a term created by Charles Taylor (2012) which I introduced in the thesis of this paper, is the process by which our narratives have been reinserted into a one-world mythological worldview; mainly through the reinvention of the **cyclical** narrative, as I have been discussing this far. I am now going to address the argument that this Modernist and especially **Postmodernist re-embedding** is greatly responsible for the **Meaning** Crisis we are now suffering. In the same manner the **Enlightenment** critiqued two-world mythology and later Modernism and **Postmodernism** critiqued **teleology**, an academic movement to counter the **Meaning** Crisis seems to be an inevitable and necessary step, beginning with the critique of **Postmodern cyclical** narratives.

The **cyclical** narrative gave writers a powerful tool to formally trespass the boundaries of cause and effect. Together with its circular nature, which challenged the idea of progress, this narratological model also enhanced concepts such as simultaneity (within characters and the story itself), "thrownness" (Heidegger, 1996) as a narratological technique, etc. Fortunately, this brought forth rich literature, but simultaneously played dangerous games with the **meaning** extracting mechanisms that we had cultivated for thousands of years in the form of two-world mythological narratives. The huge problem with the **cyclical** narrative is that it is fundamentally a one-world mythological structure. Consequently, it re-embeds us into the everyday world, where the only intrinsic realities are **material** and power. It is a worldview which downplays **truth**, progress, development, knowledge, **wisdom**, morality and virtue, and that gets reflected in the literature it produces. The goal of **cyclical** narratives is ultimately to alter "relevance realization" (Vervaeke and Ferraro, 2013) (to alter what we find relevant), create saliency towards specific realities, and maneuver power, typically following a specific political agenda (as Hicks, 2004, suggests).

If we want to overcome the **Meaning** Crisis, it is paramount to revive the two-world mythological narratives and return to **wisdom** cultivation, progress, and practice, especially in literature. However, it is not as simple as going back to those narratives, partially because we no longer trust them, even though we operate with them. We do not belong in the **scientific** world, nor in the **cyclical** world, yet we no longer **believe** in transcendence. It is therefore necessary to learn from our own critiques, to fix the mistakes of the past, and find our new contemporaneous narratological model. In **order** to do so, we must re-conceptualize the narrative including every progression, every development, and create a narratological model where our modern understanding of the world can still operate in a two-world mythological realm of progress and transcendent **wisdom**.

4. THE NARRATIVE OF TRADITIONAL COSMOLOGY

4.1. *Introduction*

This view of the narrative is intended to be fresh and novel, but has been simultaneously informed by a variety of different thinkers, most of which I have been citing along the way:

Jonathan Pageau, Matthieu Pageau, John Vervaeke, Jordan Peterson, Paul Vander Klay, among others, as well as various courses I took throughout my degree.

The model I propose in **order** to overcome the **Meaning** Crisis in the realm of literature is a narratological model akin to traditional cosmology.

I would like to revive and reintroduce concepts such as **time** and **space** as understood in the ancient cosmologies.

The **reason** why I join cosmology and narratology in my model is because I want to unite ancient and contemporaneous views of the world into a single frame.

We must make the conscious effort to understand the past because our **meaning**-making mechanisms depend on it, but at the same **time** we must take into account our present reality.

By means of utilizing traditional cosmological terminology, my aim is that the mind of the reader will expand and open itself to new possibilities.

There is great **scientific** evidence depicting how the best way to solve a problem in which you are stuck is to break your current frame in **order** to provoke an insight (Vervaeke and Ferraro, 25-29, 2013).

Hopefully, the joining of traditional cosmological terms and current day narratological terms will facilitate a much needed reformulation, and open the doors of **participatory** knowledge.

4.2. Definition

What I would like to call the narrative of traditional cosmology is:

a narratological model in which every story development is predicated on

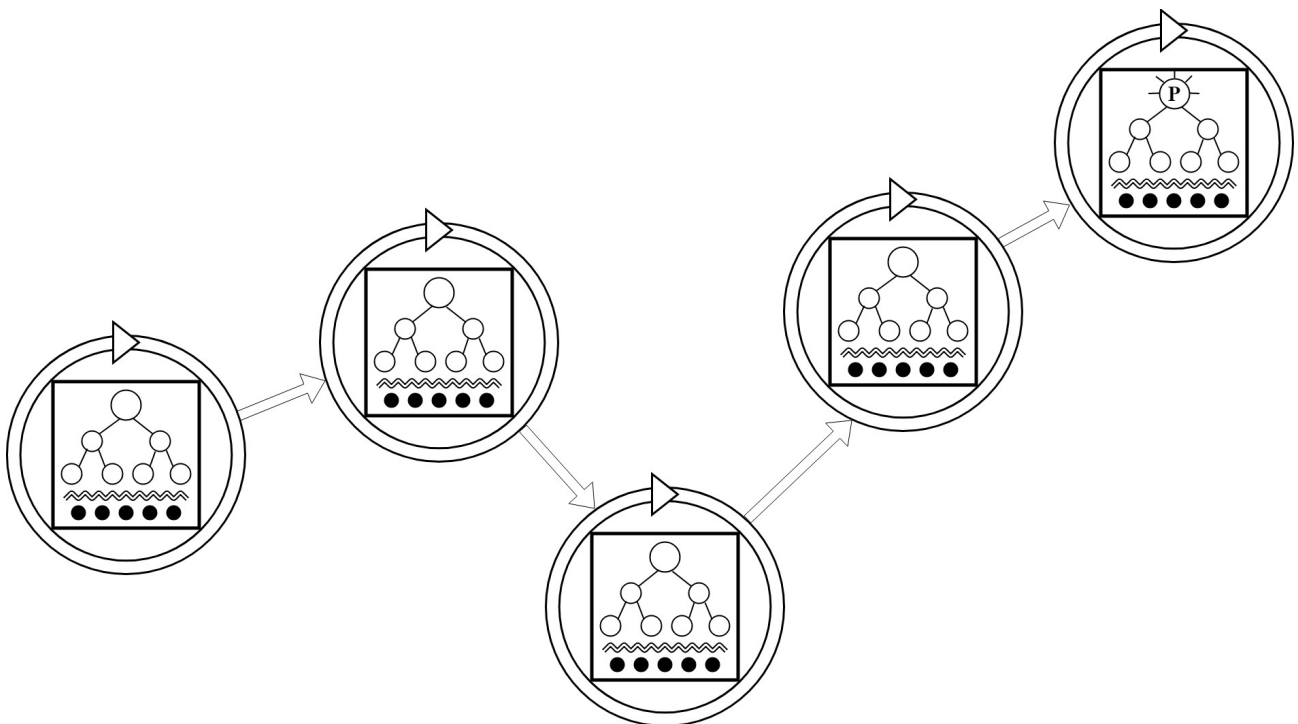
a re-structuralization of the hierarchy of consciousness
caused by **time** and outside **remainders**,
therefore altering a **fixed predictable space**,
which has to be rebuilt.

This process repeats itself in search of a **hidden meaning**.

Thus, the story progresses,

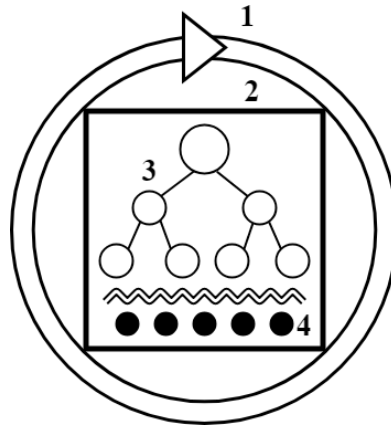
gradually revealing a pattern of **meaning** and ultimately reaching a purpose of potential.⁴

4 Words in single inverted comas are not to be read in terms of the current **scientific** understanding, but rather in the original ancient understanding part of traditional cosmology. This terms will be re-defined and developed further in the following sections.



The fundamental structure of the narrative of traditional cosmology.

4.3. Explanation of Terms and Concepts



1. Time:

In the **meaning** of traditional cosmology it is associated with "the cosmic cause of **change**" (Pageau, 116).

In other words, "it is the **influence** that carries reality from one point to another".

It does not point to specific **changes**,
but rather to **cyclical transformation**,
like the transition of the **seasons**.

It brings forth unexpected, contradictory or ironic events.

2. Space:

In traditional cosmology, it is the opposite of **time**;

"the **stabilizing** force against **transformative** forces" (Pageau, 116).

A relatively **stable** place where events are quite **predictable** and **reasonable**,
where **causality** works.

3. Hierarchy of Consciousness:

It is the hierarchical structure that consciousness naturally produces when interacting with the world, and, in this case, the story.

All conscious entities which establish a relationship with the text produce a hierarchical filter towards the reality presented in the narrative, that includes **authors**, readers and characters alike.

To the Lighthouse, by Virginia Woolf (1927) brilliantly experiments with the hierarchy of consciousness, providing the easiest gateway to understanding how it functions and the role it plays in literature.

4. Remainders:

They are "anomalous facts" (Pageau, 132) or entities within the story which question the supremacy of the first principle in the hierarchy of consciousness.

They are left-overs outside the hierarchy which, together with **time**, bring about the disintegration of **space**.

They make identity within **space** **unstable**
by pointing to unaccounted realities outside of the hierarchical framing,
thus triggering a **transformation** towards a new hierarchy.

4.4. Function and Reasoning

The whole point of the narrative of traditional cosmology is to account for all positive aspects of both the **teleological** narrative and the **cyclical** narrative, while simultaneously covering their pitfalls (covered in the respective sections).

In **order** to do so, I revive traditional terms and concepts which have been overlooked and downplayed in the modern age, such as **time**, **space**, **remainder**, etc.

Originally, these used to be common words to describe the way in which narratives relate to the world and produce **meaning**, especially in religious traditions.

However, as we adopted the **scientific** worldview, the words **story** and **reality** became false-antonyms, and we lost communion with the narratives that informed our lives.

Consequently, it is now **time** to rediscover this terminology and incorporate it into modern thinking and literary theory, as to revitalize and enhance the **meaning**-making mechanisms of our narratives.

The narrative of traditional cosmology incorporates

time as the **cyclical** element which constitutes **cyclical** narratives.

It is the **transformative** force that dismantles **space** and triggers its rebuilding.

In this case,

space functions as the **stable** and **solid** canvas typical of the narratological model of **teleology**, where **reason** and **causality** work in a quite **predictable** manner.

As we have covered so far,

by themselves these two models are largely flawed,
and they can go wrong and turn to weird places with ease,
either because of their excess of **order** and **rationality** (**teleological**),
or due to the **lack of it** (**cyclical**).

Fortunately, this dilemma can be solved by combining them together into a single model.

As **space** becomes too **rigid**, too **predictable**,
and the narrative becomes stale and unimaginative,
time can overturn it and act as a source of renewal.

Similarly,

as **time** becomes too chaotic,
and all the laws by which we operate in the world **meaningfully** fall apart,
consciousness naturally sets a **space** through its hierarchical filtering
and builds a **reasonable** frame where reality becomes manageable.

We could therefore think about

the hierarchy of consciousness as the natural causer of **space**,
and **remainders** as the natural consequence of **time**.

The way in which a **space** is established is, primarily, by a *foundation stone* or a first principle. (Pageau, 132)

The first principle is the element of the narrative that captures all attention and becomes a pillar by which everything else gains its identity in relationship to it.

The result is a hierarchical structure with the first principle in its head.

By establishing this hierarchical structure with the reality of the story, a network of agent-arena relations is built, which enables proper interaction with **meaning**, as it facilitates a **participatory** integration with the world of the narrative. (Vervaeke, Mastropietro, Miscevic, 2017, sec. 3.4.3)

The aim of **space** is not necessarily **predictability** or the enabling of **reasoning** and **causality**, but rather the creation of a world frame in which **participation** and communion with the story is possible, as that is the main pathway towards **wisdom** and **meaning**-making.

To visually represent this intention, the diagram shows how different **spaces** may rise or fall in relation to the purpose of potential, hinting that not all **changes** are going to be **predictable**, **causal**, or even desirable, but that they ultimately play a role in the whole.

This conceptualization of **space**, which is highly aware of consciousness as the main vehicle of human experience, is the response to **rigid teleological** narratives.

However, this conceptualization of **space** alone is not enough, because the hierarchy of consciousness is incapable of encompassing everything; we cannot account for the whole picture, as the amount of information and detail would overwhelm us.

As a result, **remainders** are created, unaccounted facts, which we could think of as the natural consequence of **time**; **cyclical repetitions** naturally accumulate outsider realities which are not incorporated into the hierarchy of consciousness.

Once there are too many **remainders**, to the point where their existence is no longer negligible, the hierarchy has to account for them and incorporate them, thus triggering a rebuilding of the whole.

This **transformation** makes the story progress, and with each **transformation** the worldview of the story becomes richer and more complete, thus gradually revealing a 'hidden' purpose of potential.

Consequently, when paired with **space**, the **cyclical** element of **cyclical** narratives becomes way more **meaningful** and insightful, not only because they counterbalance each other, but also because there is a purpose to the chaotic element of **time**: renewal.

As a result, the main pitfalls of **cyclical** narratives, which could be described as something akin to **nihilism**, a lack of a moral structure, **meaninglessness**, inversion, etc, are surpassed.

Moreover, **time** is directly linked to progress and growth, similarly to the Aristotelian model (Aristotle, 1981).

4.5. *The Importance of Purpose, Communion and Practice*

The only element left to elaborate on would be what I labeled as the purpose of potential, the closure point of the narrative of traditional cosmology.

It is quite an abstract idea, but it boils down to the following premise: according to this model, all narratives move towards a purpose.

This does not mean that all stories should be moralistic tales, or fairy tale-like narratives; we must disassociate the concept of purpose with a certain sense of narrow originality or **predictability**, as it has now become a trend in some circles of literary theory and critique, hence the name "purpose of *potential*".

It does not refer to grand conclusive finales either; the sort of ending where all **truths** are unveiled and everything becomes crystal clear, where everything is seemingly "in the right place".

The building towards a purpose of potential leaves appropriate room and distance for unexplored mysteries to be left untouched: **remainders**, if you will (as shown in the final section of the diagram in 4.2).

The purpose of potential is not completely an ends, but rather a means.

The narrative of traditional cosmology flows towards a purpose, building it in each step.

That purpose is not only realized at the end of the text, but rather manifests itself in various forms all throughout it.

It is a symbolic structure that extends itself in the whole of reality, manifesting repeating patterns that hint towards a greater potential.

The only **reason** why the conclusion of the narrative expresses more fully that purpose of potential is because the whole text has provided enough experience, enough opportunities for **participation** with the reality of the narrative, for it to finally be revealed in a way where it can be grasped.

Often, when discussing **Postmodern** texts with university colleagues and other academics, the most frequent critique or complaint I hear is that they cannot "connect with the text".

The way in which we consume and produce literature nowadays has undermined two very important concepts: communion and practice.

Literature was never meant to be an intellectual exercise of wit, morality and politics; it is meant to be practiced, it is meant to be lived and shared.

There is no point to stories which cannot be dwelled, where walls are built around **meaning**, where there is no **meaning**, where **wisdom** is mistaken for expedience, where human relationships are nothing more than power games.

As human beings, we need purpose, we need potential, we need an underling structure, we need a **solid ground**, as well as renewal; we require **wisdom**, we search for a story to practice, a story that grants and facilitates communion.

That is what the narrative of traditional cosmology offers; that is the literary antidote I propose for the **Meaning** Crisis.

5. EXAMPLES

5.1. *Teleological Narrative*

- *Hansel and Gretel* (German fairy tale recorded by the Brothers Grimm, 1812): One of the most well-known fairy tales of all **time**, a classic moral tale, and also a perfect example of a **teleological** narrative. Hansel and Gretel's parents decide to abandon them in the woods because they are too poor to maintain them. The despair that the kids feel once they realize they have been cast away gets mixed in with their desire to be nurtured and **loved**. Consequently, they magically meet a paradise-like **space** where everything they ever wished for is fulfilled. However, that same desire eventually turns against them in the form of self-absorbing greed and self-destructive over-protection, represented by the witch. Eventually, they manage to escape out of the situation making use of their **reason** and wit, and they evade death by becoming self-sufficient, independent and awake individuals. In this classic short tale, we can observe both the **influence** of the **Enlightenment** (in the stress of **reason** and individual autonomy), as well as the **influence** of traditional **teleological** narratives, because they awake from their false world of desires and self-deception, ultimately transcending it and rising into the higher reality of their poor family, with whom they finally reunite.
- *Robinson Crusoe* (1719) by Daniel Defoe: Considered to be the first English novel and a symbol of colonialism, *Robinson Crusoe* is a perfect example of the **influence** of the **Enlightenment** in literature, especially in **teleological** narratives, as well as how the movement of **rationality** produced the extreme consequence of colonialism. Crusoe **believes** in his supreme justice, has unbreakable religious **beliefs**, is never tempted by his sexual desires, and always tries to maintain maximum efficiency in everything he does. When he acknowledges that he will have to live in the island as a castaway, he immediately recognizes his **authority** over the land, his **authority** over the everyday world, and he acts as if the island was his own territory. When he rescues his native "friend", he chooses to name him, which usually would be considered a form of **love** and affection, however, he names him "Friday", which only reveals a logical connection indicating the day of the week he met him. Crusoe remains **rigid** and **authoritarian**, and his attitude towards the world is one of dominance through **reason**, rather than a self-disclosing **love**. Although Crusoe's resilience is admirable, his purpose is non other than to increase his control over his everyday world, to accumulate power, which given his circumstances one may consider appropriate to an extent, but his degree of imposition, absolute **rationality** and slight lack of feelings perfectly exemplifies what Romanticism and later Modernism would critique.

5.2. Cyclical Narrative

- *Waiting for Godot* (1953) by Samuel Beckett: The structure of this play perfectly exemplifies the contemporaneous **cyclical** narrative. It is divided in two acts, and Act II is a **repetition** of Act I, but with slight **changes**. According to **Postmodern** theory, it is precisely in those small differences in each **cycle** where development is found, which seems to be supported by the attention to detail and nuances, as well as the effect that those have in the overall play. Furthermore, one of the most impactful differences we see in the **repetition** of Act I in Act II is the redistribution of power reflected in Pozzo and Lucky. In Act I, Pozzo is the dominant one, while Lucky is apparently powerless; meanwhile, in Act II, it is Pozzo who appears blind and vulnerable, while Lucky is the one who has a bit more agency. This re-distribution of power perfectly illustrates my arguments regarding the relationship between **cyclical** narratives and one-world mythology (see 3.2 and 3.3).
- *The Homecoming* (1965) by Harold Pinter: This is once more a **Postmodern** play divided in two acts that mirror each other, although not as plainly as in *Waiting for Godot*. Via the use of irony, another major resource of **Postmodern** art, the title would seemingly make reference to Teddy's homecoming, but that gets flipped around in Act II. While in Act I we are introduced to Teddy's family, a woman-less family with no mother, sister-in-law or wife (because Jessie is dead), as the play unfolds and reaches its conclusion, Ruth ends up filling all the female roles of the house (mother, wife and whore), and it is instead Teddy who is forced to return to America with his kids with no mother or wife. Thus, via this inversion, the **cycle** is completed and the family situation is reversed. Essentially, the end point of the play draws a parallel with the beginning, but with the familial situation flipped around.

5.3. The Narrative of Traditional Cosmology

- 『また、同じ夢を見ていた』 [*I Saw The Same Dream Again* (approx. trans.)] (2016) by Sumino Yoru: Japanese literature is one of my biggest **influences** when it comes to my view of literature and life in general. Consequently, the model of the narrative of traditional cosmology was partially shaped by contemporaneous Japanese literature. Therefore, I thought it would be appropriate to present a Japanese novel as an example for the narratological model I propose in this paper.

I Saw The Same Dream Again (approx. trans.) is a slice of life novel following a little primary school girl, who despite being quite intelligent and mature for her age, does not have many friends. In fact, when she is at school she barely talks to anyone (except for her homeroom teacher). However, once classes are over she goes to meet three other women, who she considers to be her only true friends. One is a high school girl, the other is a young adult who "works at night", and the third is an elderly woman who lives by herself. It is all well and good until a series of problems start to occur to the little girl, who is faced with a chain of existential dilemmas, followed by some mysterious phenomenons. The **reason** why it is a perfect example of a narrative of traditional cosmology (or one that could be read according to its model) is that, as the girl uncovers more about herself, the world around her also reveals answers to her questions. At the beginning of the novel, we could consider the three women she meets everyday after school to be **remainders**, slowly piling unaccounted facts into the hierarchy of her worldview. As she incorporates said **remainders**, the world around her becomes more clear and complete, and an ultimate purpose of potential gets unveiled. Eventually, the narrative reveals how the three women were in fact phantoms of her own self in the future, who had taken different paths and committed various different mistakes. Once they help the little girl reorient herself and aim properly in life, they one by one disappear, because they are **remainders** that have been incorporated into the hierarchy of consciousness. When the three women have been assimilated into the hierarchy, the purpose of the story gets slowly revealed: the little girl is able to **participate** in reciprocal **love** with her **loved** ones. Furthermore, there is of course a **cyclical** element to the narrative, represented by intermediate sections between each conversation the girl has with the three women. These sections, where the protagonist walks from one place to another with the company of her cat, are literally **repetitions**; almost identical paragraphs where she sings the same song every **time**. These intermediate sections are obviously **time** which does not have a chaotic function (its purpose is not to set the narrative upside down or any other function it may have in **Postmodern** works), rather, its end is renewal; it is the **cycle** that separates events and delimits the **space** that each conversation sets.

- *The Lion King* (1994) directed by Roger Allers and Rob Minkoff: Another great example of a story that fits very nicely in the model of the narrative of traditional cosmology. At the beginning of the film, Scar is the obvious **remainder** of the story; he not only is plotting the unaccounted fact of the murder of Mufasa, he is also literally not part of the social hierarchy of the animals; he is an outcast which has not been integrated into the whole. The eventual murder of Mufasa is an example of how **changes** in the hierarchy of consciousness may not be desirable (Scar must be reintegrated into the hierarchy for the murder to happen in the first place, therefore, he reestablishes **space** in a negative fashion). When the murder of his father occurs and Simba is exiled from his people, he sets a **space** in the jungle where he avoids taking into account any of the responsibilities of his life (**remainders**). Later on, when Nala comes to speak with him, she is playing the function of a **remainder** as well, she reminds Simba that he has to reincorporate all of the unaccounted facts he has been ignoring up until that point. When later Simba encounters the spirit of his father in a vision, he reestablishes his hierarchy to be properly oriented and sets a **space** that takes into account the events from the past, the circumstances of the present, and the possible path towards a brighter future (**purpose of potential**). As a consequence, his purpose becomes more clear, revealing what his next step should be, and he once again presents himself to his people. Throughout the film, the musical sections are the representation of **time**. This may be a bit complex to understand, but, essentially, music is a form of renewal, where seemingly chaotic sounds are **ordered** into a melody that creates play, entertainment and pleasure, while delimiting the **order** of **space**. For instance, the opening and the ending sequences of a TV show delimit the content of the show within the greater context of the TV channel. Similarly, the musicals in *The Lion King* serve as a form of renewal and also delimit **space**, creating a distinction between the different sections of the movie, as well as the different stages of maturity of Simba.

5. CONCLUSIONS

The **Meaning** Crisis is present everywhere around the globe in many subtle and noticeable forms, spreading in all aspects of human experience like a virus, threatening the possibilities of **meaningful** engagement with life.

Literature is one of the realms that has been endangered by our current state of confusion, disagreement and suffering.

This project has aimed to explain as briefly, concisely and clearly as possible how the **Meaning** Crisis developed in the narrative and what its current form is.

The pages of this paper have explored how the **teleological** narrative got **transformed** by the **Enlightenment**, as well as how the **cyclical** narrative of **(Post)modernism** was a critical response to it.

By analyzing the strong points of both models, as well as their respective pitfalls, I have finally presented the reader with a new alternative narratological model, called the narrative of traditional cosmology, which purpose is ultimately to be a bridge between the two.

That is the potential antidote to the **Meaning** Crisis I developed after all of my research. To conclude, I would like to present my philosophy going forward, as well as why I decided to write such a project.

First and foremost, when writing a research paper there is, broadly speaking, two main approaches an academic can take.

The first would be to research about a particular topic from scratch with a hypothesis in mind, not knowing what the final result is going to be, nor if there is going to be a result to begin with; it is a trial and error.

The second method would be something akin to what I decided to go for, which is essentially the academically supported presentation of an already established idea, which is only modified slightly throughout the research process up until the very end.

While I have enjoyed the first approach a few **times** during my undergraduate years, in this particular instance

I felt the need to go for the second kind, as my ideas regarding the topic were not only extremely strong and prominent in my mind, but also quite unique and creative.

Nevertheless, and despite what the final result may appear to be, I wish to express that my eyes were open the whole way; I tried to be as open-minded and broad as I could.

Despite the fact, I found my complete argument to be rather **solid**, and therefore I thought it was appropriate to be bold and present it as a worth-discussing perspective.

This brings me to my next point, which is the format of my argument.

Originally, I wanted to write a critique of **Postmodernism** as what in my mind was the "main causer" of the **Meaning** Crisis in the literary front.

However, I decided not to take said angle for two main **reasons**.

Firstly, because I would be ignoring how **Postmodernism** came to be, failing to understand its motivations and **reasons** for existence as well as its distinction among academics.

I did not consider that to be fair or just, especially taking into account the complex nature of the **Meaning** Crisis.

Secondly, and perhaps even more importantly, I did not want to make a pure critique.

I truly **believe** the **Meaning** Crisis is a serious problem we are dealing with.

Consequently, spending the span of 20-30 pages explaining how bad or wrong **Postmodernism** is simply because I may personally slightly dislike it seemed not only futile, but extremely counterproductive;

it would create another vicious **cycle** where nothing gets resolved and more salty contempt gets added into the mix.

If I have realized something over the past four years is that I do not wish for any more conflict.

As a result, I instead decided to research and write about a full historical analysis, as complete and concise as I possibly could manage, only to close it out with the proposal of a potential solution to the problem.

The narrative of traditional cosmology is my answer to the **Meaning** Crisis in the realm of literature, but that does not mean that it has to be the unique and definitive response.

There may be counterarguments to it, maybe the argument itself is full of holes I did not notice, but even so, I present it to you as part of a bigger, overarching discussion.

I wish to be constructive, not destructive;

I wish to be truly inclusive, not pretend that I am.

In **order** to do so, I had to make the first step; the cards had to be set on the table.

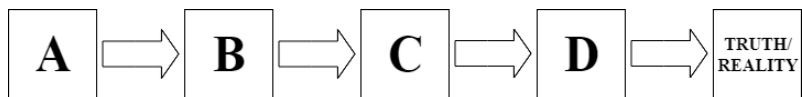
If I ask anything out of the reader,
is for them to open their arms as well, and cooperate in the debate.

That too could possibly be an antidote to the **Meaning** Crisis.

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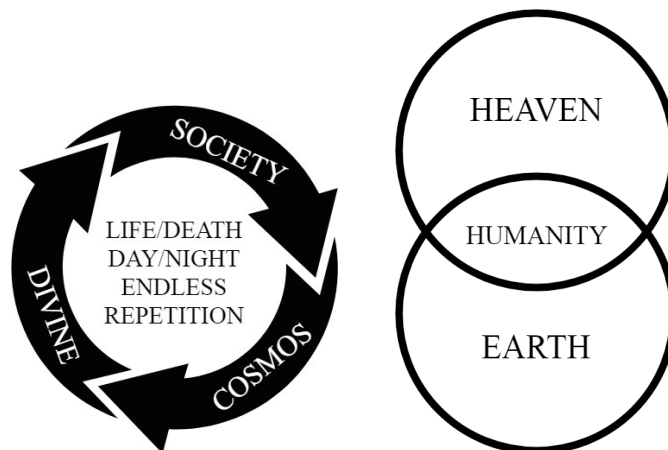
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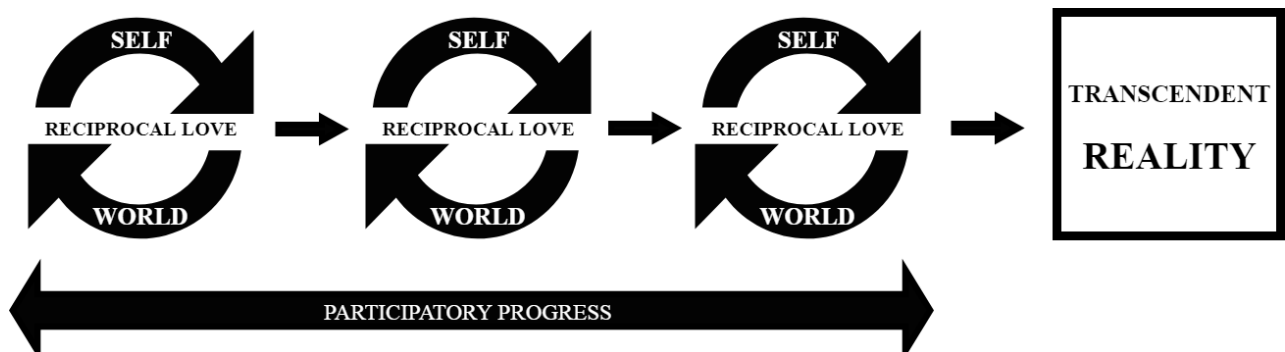


□ → Fixed space; predictable causality.

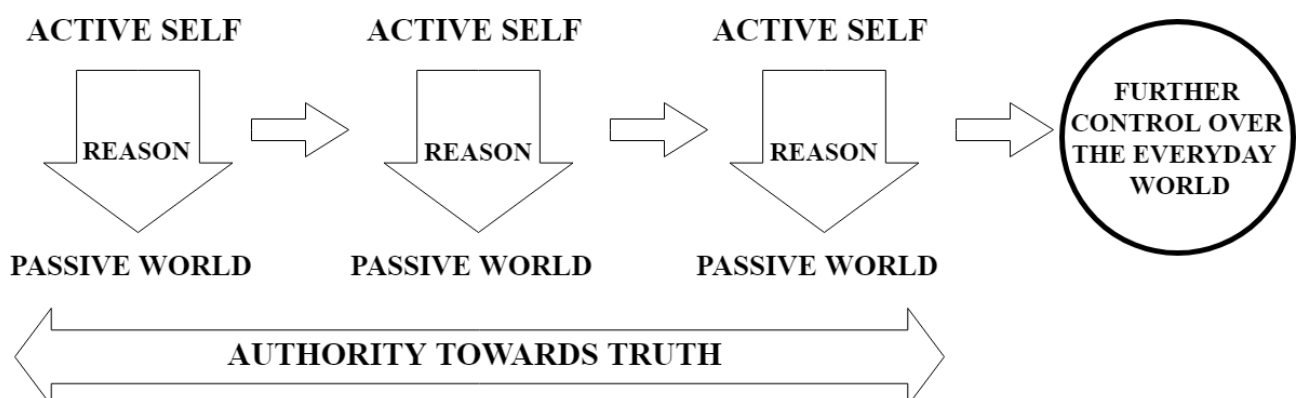
*The fundamental structure of the **teleological** narrative.*



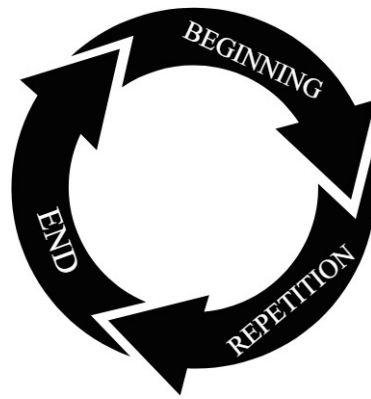
*The fundamental structures of
the **continuous** cosmos (left) and the **two-world** mythology (right).*



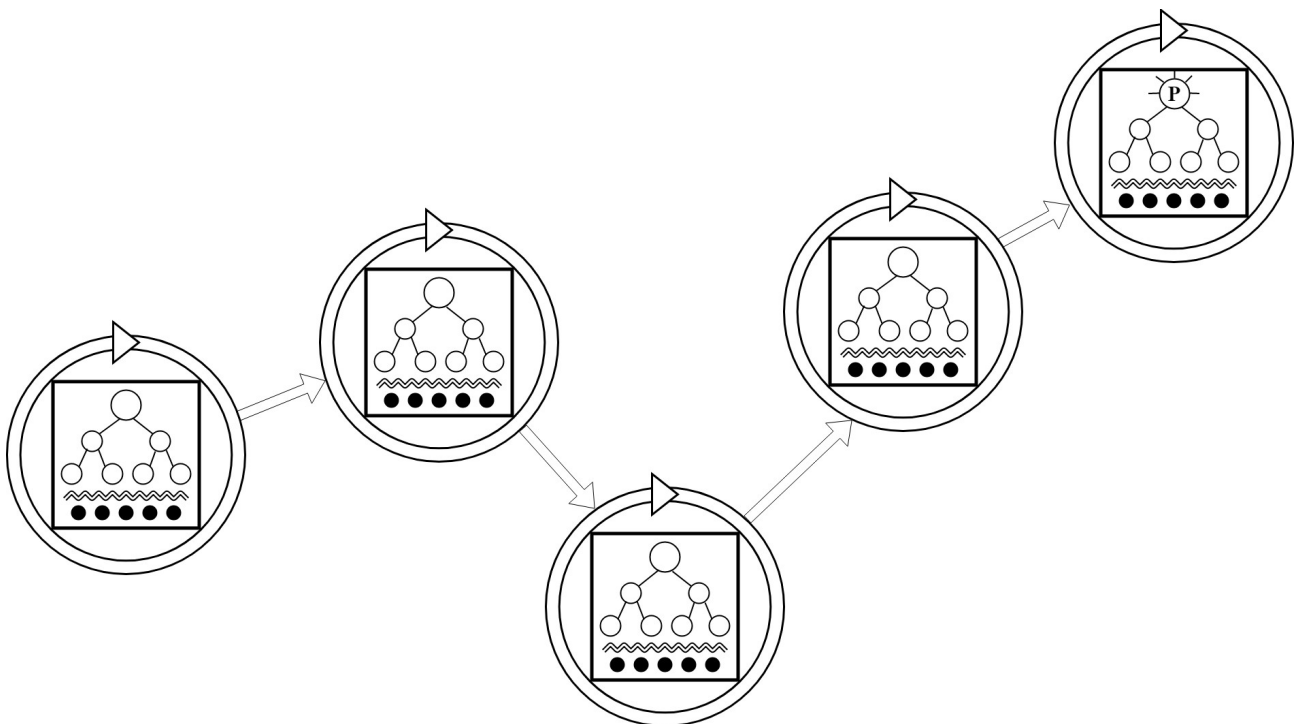
*The **teleological** narrative before the **Enlightenment**.*



*The **teleological** narrative after the **Enlightenment**.*



*The fundamental structure of the **cyclical** narrative.*



*The fundamental structure of the narrative of **traditional cosmology**.*

